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Credits and Notices

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Cover, portrait, and map visuals were generated with Microsoft Copilot and selected by Andrew James Connor and Else.

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Content notes: apparent mauling; mob violence; coercive rescue; loss of home; uncertainty about death and transformation; and the unexplained destruction of a settlement.

Adventure at a Glance

- Level 5; milestone advancement to Level 6
- Social mystery, wilderness exploration, moral choice, and limited combat
- Theatre-of-the-mind encounters
- The Lantern Circus remains the PCs' travelling home
- The PCs drive investigation, priorities, confrontation, and aftermath
- Miguel's transformation is possible, not mandatory
- No mandatory player handouts

CENTRAL TRUTH

The village remembers that leaving is dangerous, but has forgotten the difference between danger and prohibition. Fear preserved the warning after it lost the reason.

- Approximately three to five standard sessions

Levels and Advancement

- Begin at Level 5.
- Advance to Level 6 after immediate consequences are resolved and the Lantern Circus leaves The Village.
- Advancement does not depend on Miguel transforming, the Sister surviving, winning a combat, or changing the villagers' beliefs.

Adventure Overview

The Lantern Circus reaches a village whose proper name has vanished from living memory. Its people are born, live, and die within the forest boundary. They remember that people disappeared beyond the trees, but not when the prohibition began or why an old road once crossed the boundary they now fear.

The PCs' arrival proves that the outside world exists and that travellers can survive it. Miguel is fascinated by that proof. Marianne loves him without claiming his choices. Juan, Miguel's brother, understands both Miguel's longing and the village's fear. Beyond an old bridge lives the woman villagers call a Witch: a Sister whose duty is to protect people from dangers the village remembers only imperfectly.

The circus already has a known northern bypass road for departure. The PCs have reason to examine the old southern road because its construction contradicts the prohibition, because no villager can explain where it once led, and because the strange loss of the village name suggests that more has been forgotten. Their exploration reveals an old route, ordinary wilderness danger, and an immense Black Eagle. Their discoveries give Marianne reason to seek the Witch's knowledge and give Miguel reason to pursue the Eagles. When fear turns into a Hunt, the PCs' route and use of time determine who survives and what they witness.

Expected Timeline

Stage	Likely events
Arrival	Circus encamps beside the northern bypass; PCs explore The Village; Miguel, Marianne, and Juan approach.
Investigation	PCs cross the southern boundary, face the stream and wolves, discover the old road, and witness the Black Eagle.
Answers	PCs follow the bridge lead or accompany Marianne to the Sister; the party returns to The Village.
The Hunt	Miguel leaves. Scenes 5–8 are continuous; both groups keep moving while the PCs act or rest.
Departure	Consequences, farewells, Level 6, departure, and the later report that The Village is gone.

Running the Adventure

Each scene explains why it begins, what it must accomplish, where important people are, what those people want, and what occurs without PC intervention. Read-aloud contains only what characters directly perceive. Scene Exit states what carries forward.

Do not call for a D20 Test when a good plan, relevant expertise, or decisive evidence already resolves the situation. Failure may cost time, position, resources, trust, or advantage, but never removes an essential clue.

Creature names shown in bold use standard published creature stat blocks. Their statistics are not repeated here. Black Eagles are never combatants and have no stat block in this module.

DM REFERENCE

The old prohibition once meant: do not enter the Between unprepared. The Sister protects

people. The Black Eagles preserve balance. Miguel's desire for freedom brings those purposes into conflict with the village's Fear of Change.

Four Questions for a Lost DM

- Where are the PCs: at the bridge, following Miguel, with the search party, at the circus, or split?
- Has the bridge confrontation resolved, and is the Sister alive?
- Have the PCs reached Miguel before, during, or after the initiation?
- What did the PCs personally witness, and what are villagers only inferring?

The Lantern Circus

The Lantern Circus remains the PCs' travelling home. Bring forward only People, Practical, and Tradition developments recorded in Modules I and II. They may provide familiar shelter, supplies, skills, responsibilities, and customs; they do not introduce a separate circus problem. The circus has a known northern bypass road and does not need the old southern road in order to leave. During the Hunt, the circus remains safe. Rest works normally, but events at the bridge and clearing continue.

Adventure Flow

- Arrival: the PCs explore the village, discover its missing name, and meet Miguel, Marianne, and Juan.
- Investigation: the PCs scout the road, cross the boundary, survive the forest, and witness the Black Eagle.
- Answers: the Eagle's route, villagers' stories, or Marianne's request leads toward the Sister beyond the bridge.
- Escalation: Miguel leaves; the village divides into a mob moving against the Sister and a search party following Miguel.
- Choice: the PCs decide whether to save the Sister, go directly to Miguel, split up, travel with the villagers, or rest.
- Initiation: PCs who arrive in time can influence Miguel; late arrivals witness only torn clothing and fourteen Eagles.
- Aftermath: the village interprets what it can see, the circus departs, and a later report reveals the village's destruction.

Before You Begin

Preparation	Required action
Continuing records	Bring forward current People, Practical, and Tradition developments from Module II.
Route responsibility	Identify which PC normally scouts, maps, handles animals, or evaluates uncertain routes.
Player authority	Present evidence and consequences, but never decide what a PC believes Miguel should choose.
Hunt outcomes	Keep all six route outcomes visible from Scene 5 through Scene 8.
Circus presence	Use one familiar circus person, duty,

	resource, or custom only when it appears naturally. Do not create a circus subplot.

Principal Village Cast

Miguel

Restless and curious. He works, contributes, and refuses to let custom choose his life. He wants freedom, not power.

Marianne

Persistent hope. She loves Miguel without treating love as ownership. When nobody else will look beyond the old prohibition, she is willing to cross the bridge in search of answers.

Juan

Miguel’s brother. He understands why Miguel wants more and why the village is afraid.

The Sister

A solitary guardian who protects people, knows the old warning has degraded, and refuses to claim certainty she does not possess.

Scene 1: The Village

The circus arrives late in the day and establishes its field outside the homes. Nothing demands heroics. This scene gives the players time to understand the village before asking them to leave it. The mystery is not that the village is openly hostile; it is that ordinary life has become so inward-looking that nobody notices what has been lost.

Purpose

Establish the village, its absent name, the church and Elders, the old road, and the relationships among Miguel, Marianne, and Juan. Provide several reasons the PCs might later examine the old road beyond the boundary.

DM Situation

Villagers are curious about strangers and uneasy about travel. The circus can leave by the known northern bypass. The PCs may investigate the old southern road because its existence contradicts the prohibition, villagers cannot explain it, the forgotten name suggests lost history, or Miguel’s questions make the contradiction personal.

READ ALOUD

The road narrows between worked fields and low stone walls before opening onto a village that seems to have been waiting in the same place for a very long time. Children stare openly. Adults are more careful. Behind you, the circus becomes bright canvas and familiar routine. Ahead, life continues as though roads were made for arriving, never leaving.

Let the PCs Explore

Ask where each character spends the next part of the day. Present only the places they visit: the square and well, church, Elders, old road, village homes, or circus field. The party does not need to remain together.

The Village Has No Name

Let the question arise naturally when a PC asks where the circus has arrived, fills out a route note, speaks to a villager, or studies a map. Do not put player dialogue into read-aloud. Instead, give the DM the villager's response.

If asked the village's name. The villager looks puzzled by the question and answers, "It is the village." If asked again: "Home. Here. What else would we call it?"

Other residents answer with "the village," "home," or "here." A church register already uses "the village." A local map marks fields, paths, bridge, and forest but leaves the settlement unlabeled. Residents remember personal names and ordinary history. This is not general memory loss; the proper name ceased to be used and finally disappeared.

The Square and Well

READ ALOUD

A child points toward the circus wagons. "How many villages have you seen?" An adult carrying bread touches the child's shoulder. "Enough questions." The words are gentle. The child lowers their eyes, but keeps looking at the road.

Several adults listen if a PC answers. One asks how travellers avoid becoming lost. Another says distant places sound kinder in stories. Every disappearance story is older than the person telling it.

The Church

The church is modest, clean, and sincere. Carved panels show planting, harvest, marriage, sickness, burial, and families beneath one roof. No panel shows departure. A worn inscription reads, "Keep what was entrusted. Leave no one to the road."

Church elder. "A warning does not have to please us to have value."

If pressed. "You arrived from elsewhere. That proves elsewhere exists. It does not prove the road is merciful."

Religion confirms ordinary practice. Investigation or History can reveal that the inscription is newer than the building, suggesting the absolute doctrine developed later.

The Elders and Old Road

The Elders remember that villagers left and did not return, but none can identify the first disappearance. Different Elders name different generations. The maintained lane continues into forest without gate or guard; social expectation is the barrier.

READ ALOUD

An older villager sees you studying the road. "You can walk it. Nobody will tie you here." The speaker looks toward the trees. "Do not confuse that with nobody caring whether you come back."

Miguel, Marianne, and Juan

The three villagers approach the circus together, although their reasons are not identical. Miguel wants to hear about the world beyond the trees. Marianne has brought a repaired leather strap for one of the wagons and uses the errand to observe Miguel's reaction to the travellers. Juan follows because Miguel's interest in outsiders is already familiar to him, and because leaving Miguel alone with that interest has never made the questions disappear.

READ ALOUD

Three villagers approach while the circus field is still taking shape. The oldest appears close to forty, broad-shouldered from ordinary work but dressed without any sign of office or rank. A younger villager walks beside that figure carrying a repaired length of wagon leather, while another follows a few steps behind with the watchful patience of someone accustomed to knowing what the first will say before it is spoken.

The oldest lifts a hand. “Miguel.” The villager with the strap adds, “Marianne. My father is the blacksmith. This belongs to one of your wagons.” The third says, “Juan. Miguel is my brother.”

Beginning the Conversation

Miguel’s attention moves immediately from the wagon repair to the travellers themselves. Ask which PC answers. Miguel listens closely and asks follow-up questions whenever the answer names another settlement, a distant region, a larger road, or a place where people choose when to leave.

READ ALOUD

Miguel asks, “What is the farthest place you have ever seen?”

If the answer names another village, town, city, coast, kingdom, or plane, Miguel leans forward. “How long did it take to reach? How many roads lead there? Do people leave whenever they want?”

Marianne watches Miguel rather than the speaker. “That does not mean nobody worried,” Marianne says.

Juan folds both arms. “Worry is not the same thing as being wrong.”

What the Three Reveal

Miguel. Miguel is an unmarried villager nearing forty who works, contributes, and has questioned village rules for years. Miguel is not planning to flee that evening and does not ask the PCs to take anyone away. The conversation reveals fascination, not a prepared scheme.

Marianne. Marianne is the blacksmith’s first daughter. An old promise once suggested that Marianne and Miguel might build a life together, but neither now speaks of it plainly. Marianne does not want Miguel to vanish, yet refuses to call possession protection.

Juan. Juan is Miguel’s younger brother, respected and dutiful. Juan understands that Miguel’s questions are sincere and that villagers truly disappeared. Juan is not an antagonist; Juan fears that either choice may cost a brother.

Likely Questions and Responses

Why has Miguel never left?“Because wanting to know what lies beyond the trees is not the same as knowing how to survive it. And because leaving everyone you know is not a small thing.”

Does Miguel hate the village?“No. If I hated it, leaving would be easy.”

What does Marianne want?“For Miguel to make a choice because it is true, not because fear or strangers made it for him.”

What does Juan want?“A choice that brings my brother home alive. I have not found one that also leaves him free.”

If the village is mocked.Miguel replies, “People disappeared. That part is real. I just don’t think fear remembered the whole story.” Marianne emphasizes the second sentence; Juan emphasizes the first.

Reasons to Cross the Boundary

- Investigate why a substantial old road crosses a boundary nobody claims to use.
- Investigate why an old maintained route continues beyond a prohibition nobody can date.
- Test whether villagers' stories match the landscape.
- Follow Miguel's curiosity without allowing him to lead the party.
- Examine the bridge or seek the person villagers call the Witch after hearing contradictory stories about her.

Why the Old Road Matters

The circus can leave by the northern bypass and does not need this road. The old road matters because earlier generations built beyond the boundary, maintained the route, and then stopped carrying the reason forward. Its existence is physical evidence that The Village's present certainty is incomplete.

If the PCs ask the circus.A familiar company member can say, "We already know the road north. What I cannot explain is why anyone built that road south if nobody was ever meant to use it." Keep the speaker brief; the circus does not assign the adventure.

If the PCs prefer to leave by the arrival road.The known northern bypass remains available. The missing name, contradictory dates, old construction, and the visible continuation of the lane still offer an investigation. Miguel may ask whether travellers who claim freedom are truly unwilling to look beyond one bend.

If the PCs Do Not Choose

Do not threaten the circus. The company already knows its road onward. Miguel can ask whether the PCs are willing to investigate what The Village refuses to explain, but the preparation and decision remain theirs. If the PCs still refuse, Miguel later explores alone; Scene 3 can be reached by following his trail after his absence is noticed.

SCENE EXIT

End when the PCs decide to scout or investigate beyond the boundary, or when they choose to follow Miguel after he sets out alone. State whether Miguel accompanies them, follows later, or remains behind.

Scene 2: Beyond the Boundary

The PCs leave The Village because they chose to investigate the old road, accompany Miguel, or follow him after he set out alone. State that reason before reading the forest description. The scene replaces inherited warnings with direct experience: danger is real, but the physical road proves the absolute prohibition is not the whole history.

Purpose

Provide wilderness play, reveal that people once used the route deliberately, and reach the Eagle clearing.

DM Situation

The boundary has no supernatural wall. The old road is reclaimed by forest and rain. Miguel, if present, follows the PCs' decisions and does not guide them.

READ ALOUD

The last houses fall behind you. Maintained earth gives way to roots and leaf mould. A bend in the road, a screen of branches, and the village roofs are gone. The forest does not feel empty. It feels indifferent to the fact that everyone behind you is afraid of it.

Preparing to Leave

Ask what the PCs carry, whether they inform anyone, and whether Miguel is present. If the group spoke openly about scouting, Miguel asks to accompany them. The PCs may accept or refuse. Marianne asks Miguel to return before dark but does not ask the PCs to supervise him. Juan advises caution and remains in the village unless invited for a clear reason.

READ ALOUD

The last cultivated field ends at a low stone drainage channel. Beyond it, the road narrows beneath the trees. No bell sounds. No gate closes behind you. The village simply stops, and the forest begins.

If Miguel Does Not Accompany the PCs

The PCs retain every discovery in this scene. After they return, Miguel questions them closely. If their account confirms an immense Eagle and a passable road, Miguel later follows their route alone. That private expedition occurs before Scene 5 and explains why Miguel leaves with greater certainty without stealing the PCs' first sighting.

Rain-Swollen Stream

Rope, flight, Wild Shape, tools, teamwork, or an obviously sufficient spell solves it. Where uncertainty matters, use an appropriate test. Failure costs time, modest damage, or mundane gear, never access to the adventure.

Wilderness Pressure

After the stream, a territorial Dire Wolf pack shadows the party. Use four Dire Wolves for four PCs, five for five PCs, or six for six PCs. The wolves are ordinary predators. They can be avoided, fed, frightened, driven off, or fought, and withdraw when continued attack is not worth the cost.

Running the Wolf Encounter

Before initiative.Tracks, shapes between trunks, or sudden silence can alert observant characters. Success may prevent surprise or reveal the pack's size; it does not determine whether the encounter exists.

During the encounter.Wet roots, the stream bank, and dense trunks shape movement without requiring a grid. The wolves test isolated targets and avoid obvious fire or overwhelming force.

Ending the encounter.The pack withdraws when continued attack is not worth the cost. A group that feeds, frightens, evades, or drives off the pack has resolved the danger as fully as a group that kills it.

Afterward.Let the forest return to ordinary sound before revealing the older road. The sequence should leave the PCs with evidence of understandable danger, not supernatural punishment for leaving.

Older Road

Reveal wheel grooves, retaining stones, and a broken marker. No test is required to establish that people once travelled here. Further checks can establish that the road predates the oldest consistent prohibition.

DM REFERENCE

Essential clue: people once used this road deliberately. Never hide that fact behind a failed roll.

SCENE EXIT

End when the PCs reach the broad clearing. If Miguel is not with them, note that he can later follow the same evidence and see the Eagle for himself.

Scene 3: The Black Eagle

The defining sight belongs to the PCs. If Miguel accompanied them, this is also the moment that transforms his curiosity into a decision. If he did not, he later sees a Black Eagle on his own before Scene 5; the PCs still retain their own discovery.

Purpose

Introduce the Black Eagle as a noncombat force and create a reason to seek someone who understands the forbidden forest.

DM Situation

An immense black bird circles in full view, notices the PCs, and moves toward the bridge side of the forest before disappearing. The path in that direction shows old human passage.

READ ALOUD

The trees open onto a broad clearing. A shadow passes across the ground. High overhead, a black bird turns against the sky. Distance makes it seem ordinary until its wings open wider. Much wider. It circles once in silence, and for one impossible moment you have the sense that it is looking back.

Observe. Perception reveals scale or where it briefly settles; Nature confirms only that it exceeds an ordinary eagle.

Follow. Its movement and disturbed branches suggest the bridge route without becoming a guide.

Attack. It withdraws. Do not roll initiative.

Magic. Resolve spells normally; no effect supplies a complete account of the Circle.

If Miguel Is Present

READ ALOUD

Miguel does not look away. “All my life they told us the world ended at the trees.” A moment later: “It doesn’t.”

The Clearing Afterward

Once the Eagle disappears, let the PCs examine the clearing. Large impressions on a high branch and displaced needles confirm the bird truly settled there. Old human footprints are absent, but a narrow path once used by people continues toward the bridge side of the forest. The path is not hidden; it is simply older and less travelled than the road.

If the PCs return immediately.Villagers react first with fear, then questions. The Elders know no natural bird of that size. Someone mentions the Witch because she lives beyond the bridge and has survived outside the boundary for years.

If the PCs follow.The party reaches sight of the old bridge and discovers smoke or signs of habitation beyond it. Scene 4 can begin without returning to the village.

If Miguel saw the Eagle.Miguel asks what could make such a creature choose the forest the village forbids. Miguel does not yet announce an intention to transform; the sight becomes proof that the villagers' account is incomplete.

Why Seek the Witch?

The PCs have three natural leads. Following the Eagle's direction reveals the old bridge and a lived-in path beyond it. Returning to the village with the sighting causes frightened villagers to say the Witch beyond the bridge knows the forest. Marianne, hearing the PCs' account or Miguel's, asks to seek the Witch because the church and Elders can offer only the old prohibition.

Marianne's request. "If she lives beyond the bridge, she knows something none of us do. I will go. I would rather not go alone."

Marianne joins the journey if the PCs agree. She does not ask the questions for them or determine what they believe. If the PCs refuse, she visits the Sister alone, returns with only partial answers, and can later tell the PCs that the Witch said the warning had lost its meaning.

SCENE EXIT

End when the PCs follow the bridge lead, agree to accompany Marianne, or return to the village. If they never visit the Sister, Scene 5 still begins, but they enter the Hunt with less context.

The old bridge and the Sister's dwelling.

Scene 4: The Sister Beyond the Bridge

The PCs reach the Sister because they followed the Eagle's route, heard villagers name the Witch as someone who knows the forest, or agreed to accompany Marianne. Begin with the route that actually brought them here. If Marianne is present, she opens the meeting, but the PCs conduct the conversation and decide what to believe.

Purpose

Reveal the old warning's protective purpose and distinguish the Sister's concern for people from the Eagles' concern for balance.

DM Situation

The Sister lives beyond the bridge because her duty requires knowledge of the Between. She knows Marianne by sight but has never been welcomed into village life. She neither rules the village nor commands the Eagles.

READ ALOUD

The bridge is older than the path. Beyond, a modest dwelling stands among trees allowed to grow where they will. The woman watching you approach looks less like a creature from a story than someone long accustomed to being called one.

Approaching the Bridge

The bridge should feel like a place villagers have enlarged through fear. It is old but serviceable, spanning a stream narrow enough to hear from either bank. The path beyond shows use: cut herbs hanging beneath an eave, stacked firewood, repaired steps, and a vegetable patch. The evidence contradicts stories of a monster waiting in wilderness.

READ ALOUD

Water moves under the bridge with the ordinary sound of a shallow current. Beyond it, split firewood is stacked beneath the eaves of a modest dwelling. Herbs hang to dry beside the door. Whatever lives here expects winter, repairs tools, and walks this path often.

Why Marianne Comes

Marianne has heard Miguel question the prohibition for years, but the Eagle changes what those questions can lead to. Marianne seeks the Sister because the church and Elders have no answer beyond “do not go,” and because Marianne wants to know whether Miguel is walking toward freedom, death, or something neither word describes. Marianne does not know the way more clearly than the PCs and does not conduct the investigation for them.

Marianne at the Door

If Marianne is present, she knocks first but quickly turns the conversation over to the PCs. She asks only whether Miguel is in danger and whether the Eagle is real. The Sister answers cautiously because she does not yet know how much the visitors understand.

Warning. “The warning was never meaningless. The meaning was lost.”

Disappearances. “People vanished. Fear remembered that part very well.”

Between. “It is a danger you can enter before you understand you have entered it. Preparation helps. Certainty does not.”

Eagles. “They are concerned with balance. Humans are concerned with people. Do not confuse the two.”

Miguel. “If I answer for him, I have taught you nothing about protection and control.”

She does not know every origin, village, or Eagle rule. “There are truths I was taught, truths I learned, and truths I only suspect. I try not to confuse them.”

Running the Conversation

Let the PCs ask their own questions. The Sister answers directly when she knows, names uncertainty when she does not, and refuses only questions that demand a decision for Miguel. A successful social test may earn a more personal answer or an admitted suspicion, but essential facts are available through respectful questioning without a required roll.

If accused of causing the Eagle.“I did not call it. I could not dismiss it if I tried.”

If asked why the village is unnamed.“Names disappear when nobody believes they must be carried. Fear makes people protect doors and neglect stories.”

If asked whether other Sisters exist.“There have been others. There must be others. I will not pretend to know every road between us.”

If asked what Miguel should do.“Listen to him. Tell him what you know. Then decide whether protection gives you the right to choose in his place.”

If Marianne Came Alone

Marianne returns unsettled. The Sister was evasive about Miguel but said the Eagles are not the village’s enemy and that the warning has forgotten its purpose. The PCs can still visit later or proceed without a full explanation.

SCENE EXIT

End when the PCs understand that danger is real and the absolute prohibition has distorted an older warning. Return to the village and allow ordinary time before Miguel leaves.

Scene 5: Fear Becomes Action

After the PCs have had time to encounter the Eagle and investigate the warning, Miguel quietly leaves with a cloak, water, and a few belongings. If he was not present for Scene 3, he has since followed the route and seen the Eagles himself. Marianne notices what he took. Juan confirms Miguel is not elsewhere. The village begins organizing before the PCs reach the square.

Purpose

Show fear becoming action, establish the main search party and bridge mob, and make the timing consequences clear before the PCs choose.

DM Situation

The main search party wants to find Miguel. A smaller mob blames the Sister. Marianne collects travel gear. Juan wants to reach Miguel before fear becomes irreversible violence.

READ ALOUD

The square is fuller than you have seen it. Voices rise around the same few words: forest, witch, Miguel, Eagle. Juan argues with an Elder. Villagers gather lanterns, rope, and hunting spears.

READ ALOUD

Marianne pushes through the crowd, tying a cloak at the throat. “Everyone keeps telling me what Miguel should be afraid of. Nobody has asked what he saw.”

How Miguel’s Absence Is Discovered

Marianne notices Miguel’s water flask and old travelling cloak are gone. Juan checks Miguel’s home, the smithy, the circus field, and the first stretch of road before speaking to the Elders. The village therefore knows Miguel left deliberately, even if many refuse to accept what that means. Nobody claims an Eagle carried him away.

The Village Divides

The main search party carries rope, lanterns, blankets, and a litter because its stated purpose is rescue. The bridge mob carries hunting spears and tools because its leaders expect resistance from the Sister. Some villagers move between the groups uncertain where they belong. The PCs’ words can reduce either group, change its intent, or persuade individuals to remain behind.

Juan. Juan intends to follow the main search party unless the PCs ask Juan to delay it, accompany them, or protect Marianne. Juan refuses a plan that treats Miguel as an enemy.

Marianne. Marianne intends to follow Miguel’s likely route. Marianne will accept company but will not wait through a rest once the Hunt has begun.

The Elders.The Elders want Miguel brought home before the Eagle or Sister changes him. They do not yet know what “changed” means, which makes fear easier to fill with violence.

The Choices and Their Consequences

- Go to the bridge first, save the Sister, and continue immediately: the PCs can influence both encounters.
- Go directly after Miguel: the PCs reach him in time, but the mob kills the Sister.
- Travel with the main search party: the Sister is killed, Miguel completes the initiation, and the PCs find only the aftermath.
- Take even a Short Rest before either encounter: the Sister is killed and Miguel completes the initiation before the PCs arrive.

- Save the Sister and then rest: the Sister survives, but Miguel completes the initiation before the PCs arrive.
- Split the party and act promptly: one group can save the Sister while the other reaches Miguel in time.

DM REFERENCE

State these consequences before the players choose. Do not hide them behind a tracking test. Once the Hunt leaves the square, outside events continue while the PCs rest.

SCENE EXIT

End when the PCs choose a destination, split, or rest. Apply the matching route in Scenes 6 and 7.

Marianne follows Miguel's route unless a PC persuades Marianne to remain with Juan or the circus. Juan normally travels with the main search party unless the PCs ask Juan to delay it, accompany another group, or protect Marianne. State both locations whenever the party splits.

Scene 6: The Hunt, Part One — The Bridge

A frightened mob reaches the bridge intending to force the Sister to return Miguel. They believe she encouraged him and can command the Eagles. She can do neither. Most expect threats to work; a smaller number are prepared to seize or kill her.

Purpose

Give the PCs a direct opportunity to save the Sister and show fear becoming violence.

DM Situation

The Sister refuses to claim authority over Miguel or the Eagles. She defends herself only enough to survive and accepts a credible PC plan. Without the PCs, the mob kills her.

READ ALOUD

Lantern light gathers among the trees. Someone calls, "Witch! Send him back!" Another voice says, "We should wait for the others." The Sister remains beside the bridge.

The Mob at the Bridge

Use six to ten villagers in the scene, but only two or three begin willing to use weapons. The rest follow because they believe numbers will make the Sister comply. Give the crowd at least one hesitant voice and one aggressive leader. The PCs should be able to split the crowd rather than treating every villager as an enemy.

Aggressive leader.Demands that the Sister "undo" what was done to Miguel and treats refusal as confession.

Hesitant follower.Wants Miguel home but has never crossed the bridge and does not want bloodshed.

The Sister.Refuses to claim power over Miguel or the Eagles. The Sister remains at the bridge because retreat would expose the house and because yielding would validate the mob's belief that force commands truth.

Before Violence

Let the PCs speak. Evidence, Marianne's testimony, Juan's influence, or authority can split frightened followers from violent leaders. The bridge can be blocked with ordinary movement, spells, obstacles, or restraint.

If Violence Begins

Use Guard statistics only for villagers who actually take up weapons. Others retreat, surrender, hesitate, or refuse to fight. The Sister does not solve the encounter for the PCs.

If the PCs Do Not Arrive

The mob attempts to seize the Sister. She resists without lethal force. Fear escalates into murder, and villagers kill her near the bridge. No Eagle retaliates and no supernatural punishment follows.

After an Offstage Death

If the PCs bypassed the bridge or rested, do not reveal the death immediately unless a survivor reaches them. When the event becomes known, the Sister's body lies near the bridge, the dwelling has been searched, and several villagers carry defensive wounds. The mob did not set out announcing murder; fear, attempted seizure, and resistance became murder when nobody stopped the escalation.

Direct Path

A woodland path reaches the clearing in about thirty minutes. PCs who leave promptly still reach Miguel before his choice. If they rest after saving the Sister, Miguel completes the initiation before they arrive.

SCENE EXIT

End when the Sister is safe and the mob is no longer a threat, or when the offstage result is established. Proceed directly to the clearing unless the PCs choose to rest.

The clearing of the thirteen Black Eagles.

Scene 7: The Hunt, Part Two — Miguel and the Eagles

PCs who act promptly and travel independently reach Miguel before the main search party. PCs who saved the Sister and continued immediately also arrive in time. PCs who travel with the mob or rest after the Hunt begins arrive only after the initiation.

Purpose

Let the PCs understand and influence Miguel's choice when they arrive in time; otherwise present only the aftermath and let the PCs respond to the villagers' interpretation.

DM Situation

Thirteen Black Eagles wait around Miguel. They do not compel him, explain themselves, or fight. The village search party is slowed by fear, unfamiliar tracks, noises, and the stream.

If the PCs Arrive in Time

READ ALOUD

Thirteen black forms settle around the clearing. Miguel stands within the circle. "I am not asking you to choose this for me," he says. "I am asking you not to let fear choose it for me."

Dissuade. A meaningful argument can change or delay his choice; one unsupported roll does not overwrite him.

Force him home. Use ordinary rules. The Eagles withdraw and Miguel remains unharmed.

Accept. The PCs may stand aside without claiming certainty.

Ask for time. Miguel may delay; the offer may not return.

Attack the Eagles. They withdraw without retaliation.

Miguel Explains the Choice

Miguel does not claim that transformation is safe. Miguel accepts that change may end the life and identity the village recognizes. The Eagles have not promised power, return, or continued human memory. What Miguel wants is the right to choose possibility after a lifetime in which fear defined every horizon.

If asked what the Eagles offered.“Not words. A way forward. I know that is not the same as an answer.”

If asked whether Miguel expects to survive.“I do not know whether I will still be Miguel in the way you mean.”

If reminded of Marianne and Juan.“They are why this costs something. They are not why the choice belongs to someone else.”

If offered another life outside the village.Miguel considers a concrete, believable alternative. A vague promise that the PCs will solve everything later is not enough; a real invitation, plan, or path may be.

Let the Players Decide What Rescue Means

Do not frame intervention as obviously right or acceptance as obviously wise. Tell the players what the characters see, what Miguel says, and what remains unknown. When the Eagles close around Miguel, pause long enough for every player to declare whether the character acts. If one character intervenes decisively, the initiation ends.

A decisive intervention is any declared action that reaches Miguel, physically separates Miguel from the flock, or disrupts the flock’s movement before the initiation ends. The Eagles immediately withdraw and do not retaliate.

The Apparent Mauling

If Miguel proceeds, the Eagles descend in a mass of wings, claws, and tearing cloth. It appears they are ripping him apart. Do not reveal the outcome before the players decide whether to intervene.

READ ALOUD

Miguel steps into the open ground. The thirteen Black Eagles descend together. Wings blot out the clearing. Claws rake through cloth. Black bodies strike and wheel so tightly that Miguel disappears among them. You hear fabric tear. The movement is too fast, too violent, to see what is happening at the centre.

If the PCs Intervene

Any decisive attack, spell, rush, or rescue attempt ends the initiation. The Eagles scatter and do not retaliate. Miguel is alive, physically unharmed, and still human, though his clothing may be torn.

If the PCs Let It Continue

READ ALOUD

The black mass breaks upward. Torn pieces of Miguel's clothing settle onto the grass, but Miguel is no longer inside them. Fourteen great birds climb above the clearing. Thirteen are black. The bird leading them catches the light in gold, and for an instant its movement looks less like an eagle's than a person learning what wings are for.

If the PCs Arrive Too Late

Travelling with the search party or resting after the Hunt begins produces this branch. The PCs hear violent wings and tearing cloth ahead. By the time the clearing comes into view, Miguel is gone. Shredded clothing remains and fourteen Eagles are taking flight. Do not ask retroactively whether the PCs intervene; the earlier route or rest choice removed that opportunity.

READ ALOUD

A storm of wings erupts above the trees ahead. The search party breaks into the clearing as torn cloth settles over flattened grass. Miguel is nowhere in sight. Fourteen great birds climb into the open sky. Thirteen are black. The bird leading them catches the light in gold, and for an instant its movement looks less like an eagle's than a person learning what wings are for.

What the Search Party Sees

The villagers never witness Miguel's private explanation. If Miguel remains human, they see a living villager outside or near the broken circle and call the outcome rescue. If Miguel transformed, they see only shredded clothing and fourteen departing Eagles. Their interpretation is therefore understandable from limited evidence, even when wrong.

If Juan arrives.Juan looks first for Miguel, then to the PCs for an account. Juan does not automatically accept either "rescued" or "devoured."

If Marianne arrives.Marianne recognizes Miguel's clothing and watches the Golden Eagle longer than the others. Marianne asks the PCs what Miguel chose, not merely what attacked him.

If news of the Sister's death arrives.The search party may fracture. Some blame the Sister, others the mob, and some finally understand that fear has already killed one person whether or not they believe Miguel survived.

Villagers Arrive Afterward

If the PCs arrived first, villagers enter after the private outcome. If the PCs travelled with them, everyone enters together after the initiation. A human Miguel is called rescued, whether he agrees. Shredded clothing and no body are interpreted as proof that forest creatures killed him.

SCENE EXIT

Proceed when Miguel is human, transformed, delayed, or already gone, and the villagers' arrival has established the immediate accusation or interpretation.

Scene 8: Consequences

The clearing settles, but its meaning does not. Begin from the exact results at the bridge and clearing. Different witnesses may possess different facts.

Purpose

Resolve immediate harm, give the PCs first voice, determine what account reaches the village, and settle the consequences at the bridge and clearing.

DM Situation

Note who is alive, injured, absent, hostile, or grieving. Note whether the PCs spoke with Miguel, witnessed the transformation, or arrived only for the aftermath. Do not give them knowledge they did not witness.

The PCs Act First

Ask each player what the character does: tend wounds, lower weapons, pursue the Golden Eagle, inspect the clothes, confront villagers, protect someone, speak privately, or return home. Resolve these actions before NPC epilogues.

Miguel

Human. Villagers call him rescued. Miguel may call it persuasion, delay, or coercion.

Golden Eagle witnessed. The PCs can describe what they saw but cannot compel belief.

Aftermath only. The PCs saw fourteen Eagles and torn clothing, not Miguel's decision. They can describe only what they witnessed.

The Sister

Survives. She distinguishes observation from belief and remains a living guide to the Between.

Killed. The village lost its remaining guide because fear became murder. No immediate supernatural punishment follows.

What the Village Hears

The PCs may speak publicly, remain silent, defend Miguel, condemn the Eagles, defend the Sister, or state only observed facts. A social test may sway undecided villagers but cannot rewrite everyone.

- Questioning: some ask what the warning once meant.
- Divided: families and authorities disagree.
- Hardened: shredded clothes are treated as proof the forest kills.
- Bereaved: deaths eclipse theology or symbolism.

Conversations the PCs May Seek

Miguel remains human.Miguel can speak privately about persuasion, delay, or force. If the PCs physically prevented the initiation, do not make gratitude automatic.

Marianne. Marianne wants an honest account of what Miguel said and whether he chose. Marianne does not require the PCs to share the same interpretation.

Juan. Juan asks what Miguel wanted and what the PCs did. Juan's later position depends more on that answer than on village applause.

The Sister survives.The Sister refuses to declare the PCs morally correct. The Sister can say what danger was prevented and what freedom was denied, if either occurred.

Evidence in the Clearing

The torn clothing is ordinary fabric cut and shredded by claws. There is no human body and, after a completed transformation, no blood sufficient to support the village's certainty that Miguel was eaten. The absence proves nothing by itself. Tracks show thirteen large birds landed and fourteen departed. A careful PC can state that fact even if listeners reject its meaning.

Outcome Reference

PC choice	Sister	Miguel	PC knowledge
Bridge, then continue	Saved	Choice can be influenced	Both encounters witnessed.
Directly after Miguel	Killed	Choice can be influenced	Miguel witnessed; Sister learned later.
Travel with search party	Killed	Initiation complete	Aftermath only.
Rest before either	Killed	Initiation complete	Aftermath only.
Save Sister, then rest	Saved	Initiation complete	Bridge and aftermath.
Split promptly	Can be saved	Can be influenced	Each group knows only its own scene until reunited.

Returning to the Circus

The circus provides familiar shelter, food, equipment, sleeping places, and recorded development benefits. Do not introduce a new circus problem.

READ ALOUD

Inside the circus field, familiar wagons, canvas, tools, food, and sleeping spaces restore the proportions of the world. Beyond the field, the village is deciding what happened. Here, the road-worn routines of home continue because you returned to them.

SCENE EXIT

End when immediate danger and injuries are addressed, the PCs have chosen what account to give, and the players have completed the conversations they seek.

Scene 9: Departure

The circus leaves after the PCs have dealt with the immediate consequences. The village may remain divided, fearful, curious, or angry. This is the last time the PCs are likely to see it as a living settlement.

Purpose

Close the local events, show that home can move, reveal the village's later fate, and advance the PCs to Level 6.

DM Situation

By morning, ordinary life resumes around whatever changed. If Miguel remains human, he is available only if the PCs seek him. The circus packs because travelling is its ordinary life.

READ ALOUD

By morning, the circus is becoming a road again. Stakes come free of the earth. Canvas folds. Harness settles onto familiar shoulders. The village remains where it has always been. Your home does not.

Player-Chosen Farewells

Ask whom the PCs seek. Run only those conversations. Supporting NPCs respond to events rather than repeating the theme.

The Village Has No Name

The village does not recover its proper name. Nothing the PCs found supplies that lost word. Villagers continue to call it “the village,” “home,” or “here.”

READ ALOUD

Canvas comes down. Ropes are coiled. Wheels settle into old ruts, and the village shrinks behind you. Whatever its people choose to remember, you carry what you saw beyond their boundary: a warning that had forgotten its meaning, torn cloth in a clearing, and black wings against an open sky.

What Becomes of the Village

After the circus has moved on, news eventually reaches the company by an uncertain route: another travelling show, a merchant, or a hunter who strayed near the district. The report is always the same. Where the village stood, only ruins remain. Houses, shops, church, huts, people, and ordinary life are gone. No reliable witness can say when or how it happened.

READ ALOUD

The story reaches you farther down the road. Someone passed through the district where the nameless village should have stood and found only ruins. No market smoke. No church bell. No people. Nothing living among the flattened remains. The traveller cannot say what happened, only that the village is gone.

End with the report. Whether the village destroyed itself, was taken by the Between, lost the Sister’s protection, or suffered another consequence remains unanswered.

Carrying the Village Forward

The players may decide what the PCs believe about Miguel, the Sister, the Eagles, and the village’s destruction. Do not resolve those beliefs into one official explanation. The lasting influence of the adventure comes from the distinction the PCs have now confronted repeatedly: protecting someone from danger is not always the same as controlling a choice.

Circus Ledger

Record exactly one development in each domain. Each must arise from an event the table can name. Examples are suggestions only; the group chooses the actual entries.

Domain	Record one development	Example only
People	A responsibility, ally, or leadership role.	A regular boundary scout or route keeper.
Practical	A resource, method, skill, or service.	A route-recording or forest-scouting practice.
Tradition	A shared custom or decision-making practice.	Hear a person’s stated choice before naming intervention a rescue.

These developments grant no automatic income or bonus unless later material explicitly says so.

Milestone

After the immediate consequences are resolved and the circus takes the road, the PCs advance to Level 6. Advancement does not depend on Miguel transforming, a combat result, or reforming the village.

SCENE EXIT

Module III ends when the later report confirms that The Village no longer survives and the road carries the circus toward the next part of the Circle.

Maps

The Village and the Forest Beyond

